

States **KARNATAKA**

Block and Roll REVOLUTION

A new airport project near Bellary runs into heavy turbulence as farmers hit the road in protest against the acquisition of fertile land

| By Stephen David |

The district shot to national prominence when it elected Sonia Gandhi to the Lok Sabha, but in more recent times, Bellary in Karnataka has stayed in the news because of its mining tycoons—the Gali Reddy brothers, two of whom are members of the state Cabinet. Thanks to its mining wealth, Bellary has more privately-owned helicopters and small planes than many similar towns. These aircraft land at a private airstrip and rich vips are promising to build a swanky new airport, but Bellary's denizens, mostly farmers, are saying thanks, but no thanks.

Bellary was once a Congress bastion but is now a BJP citadel where farmers are agitating against the B.S. Yeddyurappa-led Government's decision to take over more than 1,000 acres of lush green agricultural land for the project. From farmers performing 'urulu seve'—a painful and sustained body roll, normally reserved for penances and offering pujas to their gods—to concerted legal action, the protesters are planning to leave no stone unturned to ensure that the airport plan does not take off at all. "There is no problem if they take away dry or waste land and develop that into a good airport," says farmers' leader Mallikharjun Reddy. "But we will definitely oppose the Government plan to take over fertile and irrigated lands in the Chaganur and Sirivar villages in the Bellary taluk."

CHAIRMAN OF STATE HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION S.R. NAYAK AT A PROTEST SITE (LEFT); FARMERS ROLLING ON THE ROAD



Last week, a group of farmers rolled on the road from Chellagurki pilgrim centre to Bellary city, about 25 km away, to submit a detailed memorandum to the city collector. What farmers are asking is whether Bellary actually needs a public airport and if there is any air passenger traffic volume to justify such a large project. There is a widespread feeling among locals that it is just an attempt to scare the farmers away into giving lands to the Government and then returning it to them after denotification for a big consideration.

Operating under the banner of Save Fertile Land Action Panel, Mallikharjun admits he is not opposed to an airport project per se, but his anger is against the Government's plan to gobble up "fertile and irrigated" lands. Most farmers point to the regular taxes they have been pay-

ing to the Government as proof of the quality of their agricultural land. "In a notification on land acquisition, the state Government had categorised the 'land with irrigation facility' as kushki land (dry land)," he says, warning that the farmers will not hesitate to launch a Nandigram-like agitation if the Government does not invite the farmers for talks and amicably settle the matter. The Karnataka farmers' association, the Rajya Raitha Sangha, is also pitching in with its share of protests, with its members performing a puja before they began their urulu seve in protest from Chellagurki Yerriatata temple.

The state Tourism Minister G. Janardhan Reddy, who is also one of the richest mining barons, is keen on putting Bellary on the world travel map with a state-of-the-art airport project. He can afford to